Attention Scarcity in Information-Rich Organizations (Simon 1971)

Herbert Simon established the foundational economic law of modern knowledge work: in an information-rich world, a wealth of information creates an inevitable poverty of attention, requiring organizations to design filters rather than merely adding storage.

GRADE: MODERATE | STATUS: STABLE | DOMAIN: TECHNICAL, ORGANIZATIONAL, PHILOSOPHICAL | REPLICATION: VERIFIED

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Herbert Simon formulated the governing economic constraint of digital environments: "In an information-rich world, the wealth of information means a dearth of something else: a scarcity of whatever it is that information consumes. What information consumes is rather obvious: it consumes the attention of its recipients. Hence a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention and a need to allocate that attention efficiently among the overabundance of information sources that might consume it."

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Simon analyzed communications networks, corporate management reports, and early computing infrastructures, demonstrating that adding informational bandwidth without corresponding filtering mechanisms directly degrades executive decision quality.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Field and empirical studies in organizational behavior consistently confirm that increasing document access without attentional gating leads to cognitive overload, information filtering failures, and paralysis by analysis.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

Classified as: n/a (conceptual economic framework). While the qualitative principle is universally recognized, quantitative measurement of executive attention allocation varies across corporate settings.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

This does not mean that organizations should withhold information from employees; rather, it demonstrates that storing and transmitting data without attention-allocating filters paralyzes organizational capacity.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Design enterprise systems and reporting channels that prioritize selective relevance filtering, signal condensation, and attention protection over raw document hoarding.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Simon, H. A. (1971). Designing Organizations for an Information-Rich World. In M. Greenberger (Ed.), Computers, Communications, and the Public Interest (pp. 37–72). Baltimore, MD: The Johns Hopkins Press.